Week 14

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 4 · LESSON 2

Beauty

BIG IDEA

Beauty, agency and story may seem lighter than earlier lessons, but they're important pointers to God in students' everyday lives. Use this week to step back and evaluate where each student is, so you can wisely shape the second half of the year.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. Don't rush beauty, agency and story because they seem strange. They're important pointers to God in the things students see and touch every day.
2. Ask where each student is now: revisit the questions, thoughts and beliefs they came in with and any notes you took. What has changed, good or bad?
3. Keep a few Essentials books on hand for new students, and learn whether newcomers are seekers, skeptics or church kids who just moved.
4. Watch for recurring questions. Students, especially inquisitive ones, often can't move on until a question is answered, so pause and answer it head on.
5. Don't focus only on engaged students or on one skeptic. Talk one-on-one with the student who isn't buying it, and don't forget everyone in the middle.
6. Decide how to move forward: keep going, or pause and revisit a lesson. The goal is students prepared to move the gospel forward and proclaim the kingdom.

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. Which students have changed since the start of the year, and which haven't?
2. Do I focus on the engaged students or on one skeptic, and who in the middle am I missing?
3. What recurring question do I need to stop and answer head on?

ASK YOUR GROUP

In small group: questions to ask your students.

1. Where have you noticed something beautiful this week, and what did it make you think or feel?
2. Why do you think people everywhere are drawn to beauty?
3. How might beauty in everyday life point to God, and why might it not convince someone?
4. What question from this year still feels unanswered for you?
5. Looking back on the year so far, what has changed in how you think about faith?

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WEEK 14 · LEADER VIDEO

The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Why beauty, agency and story

0:05 Last week we talked about morality, and the fact that morality points to God gives us some evidence that a divine Creator actually exists. Now, for these next couple of units, you might be thinking, "Well, why are we talking about beauty, agency and story?" These next few lessons are not as difficult as what we've tackled in the last couple of months, but don't gloss over them. Don't just fly through them like they're no big deal because they seem kind of strange. These are also incredibly important pointers to God, and they're going to help lay a foundation so that the students can see that God is present in their everyday lives, in the things they see and interact with on a daily basis.

Where are your students?

0:52 So for this week, I want you to take a step back and do some evaluation. I want you to look at some of your students and take a minute to really try to figure out where some of them are. Ask yourself a number of questions. Do a little bit of evaluation to figure out how you're going to best move forward into this next half of your year. So the first thing I really want you to do is spend some time thinking about where your students are. Where are they?

1:24 And I don't mean that they're in youth group or they're not in youth group. I mean, where are they? If you paid attention at the very beginning, think about where they came in, what they were actually thinking about, and the questions that they had. Think about some of the questions they had, and some of the thoughts or beliefs they had. Those are all important for figuring out where they are now. You may have noted a few students specifically. I would go back and look at some of those notes and see whether there has been any change, good or bad. Do they have new questions? The questions they had — have those been answered?

New students

2:08 Secondly, do you have any new students? Now that you've been going for a while, it's kind of easy to get into the rhythm and forget when new students arrive. This would be a great time to ask yourself: do you have some of our Essentials materials on hand? If I were you, I would always have five or six of our Essentials books on hand, ready to go any time a new student walks in the door, to make sure that they can be brought up to speed pretty quickly and that they don't feel super intimidated when they walk in the door and we're in the middle of this crazy big study that you guys are working on.

2:48 And if you have new students coming in, what are the questions that they have? Are they students who are seeking, or are they skeptics? Are they our traditional church students who just found a new church? Did they move? What's going on? Have some sort of matrix to

understand where your students are coming from, so that as you move forward you can track this same question for these new students.

Recurring questions

3:13 Are there recurring questions? Are there still questions? What I mean by this is, are they the same questions? Are you not answering questions? Do we have the answers yet? It's something to consider. Or are the students just constantly bringing up the same question? I don't mean questions about things you're going to get to, because you're going to get to those. I mean questions about anything that's within the curriculum so far. Are there recurring questions?

3:46 You might want to think about what you need to do — take some time, maybe pause, and actually answer these specific questions head on. Find the answers and get to them, so that the students can move on in their minds. A lot of times, if students get hung up on a question, they have a hard time moving through to the next thing. They need those things answered, and that's often true especially of some of your brighter students, who are super inquisitive and want to know things. If they have a question, they often have to have it answered. So you're going to want to stop and get those questions answered.

Who is tracking, who pushes back

4:19 Which students are tracking? This is something we often forget about. Some of our students track really well, and it might be easy for you to get hung up on those students, because as you're talking to your group, or to the people in your small group, those are the ones who are talking a lot and raising their hand, or the students who are super engaged and really, really paying attention to you. It's easy to get focused on those students. It's good to notice it, but don't get overly focused on it, because what you're going to end up doing is forgetting that there are still students who are pushing back.

5:04 Are there students pushing back on you? Is there a student — and I don't mean verbally, I mean the kid in the back who's doing this, who has that look on their face that says, "I'm not buying it. I'm just not buying it." I would engage that student, not in front of everybody, but after it's all done — before, after, whenever there's a little more one-on-one time. Ask that student, "Hey, I noticed you seem kind of questioning. Do you have a question about what I was saying?" Don't be afraid to engage that student a little bit. Those are some of the most fun students.

5:43 But I'm going to put in a caveat, because there are probably a couple of different camps, depending on where you sit. Some of you are going to get focused here, because you want that affirmation — hey, everyone's listening to me, and this is great, and I've got these students tracking. To be honest, that's sort of my push: I love the students who really, really get engaged and ask great questions and those kinds of things. Some of you might get totally dialed in to what these students are doing, and you forget everybody else.

6:16 However, some of you might get really dialed in to these students instead — like, that's my project. I want to get that student. I want to do everything I can to make sure that student believes in Jesus before they walk out of here. I'm going to get that student to accept Jesus. That's a great goal, but don't do that and forget about everybody else. It's easy to get switched on to one or the other. There's everybody else in the middle, too, and you don't want to forget them either. But ask yourself where your students are, so you get a pretty good idea.

A student I never forgot

6:48 I'll never forget one particular student that I had years ago in one of my apologetics classes. He sat in the back for probably the entire class, arms folded, feet up on the desk, looking at me like this is the dumbest class ever. Why am I here? I have to be here. I can't switch out of this class, and I'm stuck. I remember that every time I gave my lecture, or my talk, or the discussion — whatever we were doing for that day — I would focus it right on him, to make sure that I was talking to him. And I would look for little hints, little changes in the eyebrow or changes in posture and other nonverbals, just to see what he was thinking.

7:34 Then every day after class, as the students were walking out, I would ask, "So how was class today?" and ask further questions. What's going on? How are you? I'd see him in class, or in the hallway at different points in the day, and I would ask questions, even when he didn't say anything, just to get some nonverbals out of him, to see if I was making progress.

7:53 By the end, I never saw him accept Christ, but by the end he said, "There's something to what you're saying." That's all I ever got. I honestly don't know whatever happened after that. I just pray that somewhere along the line he has found Jesus. But at that moment, that was awesome, because I knew I was moving him in the right direction. Okay, so that's a whole lot of observations, a whole lot of stuff that you need to think through.

How do you move forward?

8:24 So now you need to figure out: how do you move forward? How do you go to the next level? How do you do the next sort of things that we have coming? It might just be to keep going — keep on to the next thing, keep on doing the next thing, and it's no big deal. But it might be that you put the brakes on someplace. Do you go back to an old lesson and revisit something? Think it through, and don't be afraid to make some adjustments if that's what you need to do. Because remember, there are going to be ebbs and flows, and there are going to be ups and downs. But the goal is to provide our students with what they need to be prepared to move the gospel forward and to proclaim the kingdom. That's the goal.